Do Now

Preparing students for learning

At BSCS, Do Now provides a short, independent start using spaced retrieval of previously taught, curriculum-critical knowledge. Keep the routine stable so thinking begins without a fresh explanation.

How to do it well

1 Select curriculum-critical knowledge. Use a spaced retrieval plan across recent and older content. Avoid trivia, isolated detail and one-off quiz questions.

2 Pitch for productive success. Aim for roughly three quarters correct overall: question 1 accessible, questions 2–3 secure for most, question 4 more challenging, plus an optional challenge.

3 Use clear, single-answer prompts. Prefer discrete facts, features, vocabulary, short procedures or carefully bounded explanations. Do not stack recall, explanation and application into one overloaded prompt.

4 Make the routine automatic. Display the task in the same place, use a visible timer, keep the response location consistent, and expect quiet independent thinking without notes.

5 Collect representative evidence. Use mini-whiteboards, Book-to-Board, ABCD cards, call and response or planned indicator pupils rather than volunteers alone.

6 Respond and reschedule. Correct misconceptions, model briefly where needed, use a related recheck, and return to fragile knowledge in a later Do Now.

What this sounds like

“Complete the four core questions silently, without notes. If you are stuck, move on and return. The final question is an optional challenge.”

Classroom example. A Languages Do Now retrieves vocabulary from several earlier lessons, with an accessible first item and an optional translation challenge. Students begin independently without notes. The first teacher lap checks the routine and the second samples answers. A shared vocabulary gap gets a brief repair and is scheduled for retrieval again later.

Top tips that make the technique work

Use four core questions and a challenge. An accessible first item helps everyone start; later items increase the demand without blocking all progress.

Make answers quick to inspect. A bounded response reveals more than an overloaded question with several unrelated demands.

Teach a stuck protocol. Students move to another item and return, rather than waiting with no work completed.

Make two purposeful laps. First secure participation and the routine; then inspect knowledge and likely errors.

Place prerequisites correctly. Check knowledge required for today’s new content at the opening of Explain, rather than replacing spaced retrieval with a starter on today’s topic.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Protect independent attempts before feedback.	Retrieving content students have not yet been taught.
Use a timer and proportionate review.	Turning the Do Now into a long worksheet or lengthy reteaching lesson.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

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